
Evidence in Action: Early insights and research gaps

Ghassan Baliki

Leveraging Evidence for Effective Anticipatory Action

FAO Rome | 20 April 2026

ISDC

INTERNATIONAL
SECURITY AND
DEVELOPMENT
CENTER

Targeted Review of Rigorous Evidence on Anticipatory Action:

Impacts and Research Priorities

Audrey Pereira
Dorothee Weiffen
Hanna Paulose
Tilman Brück
Ghassan Baliki

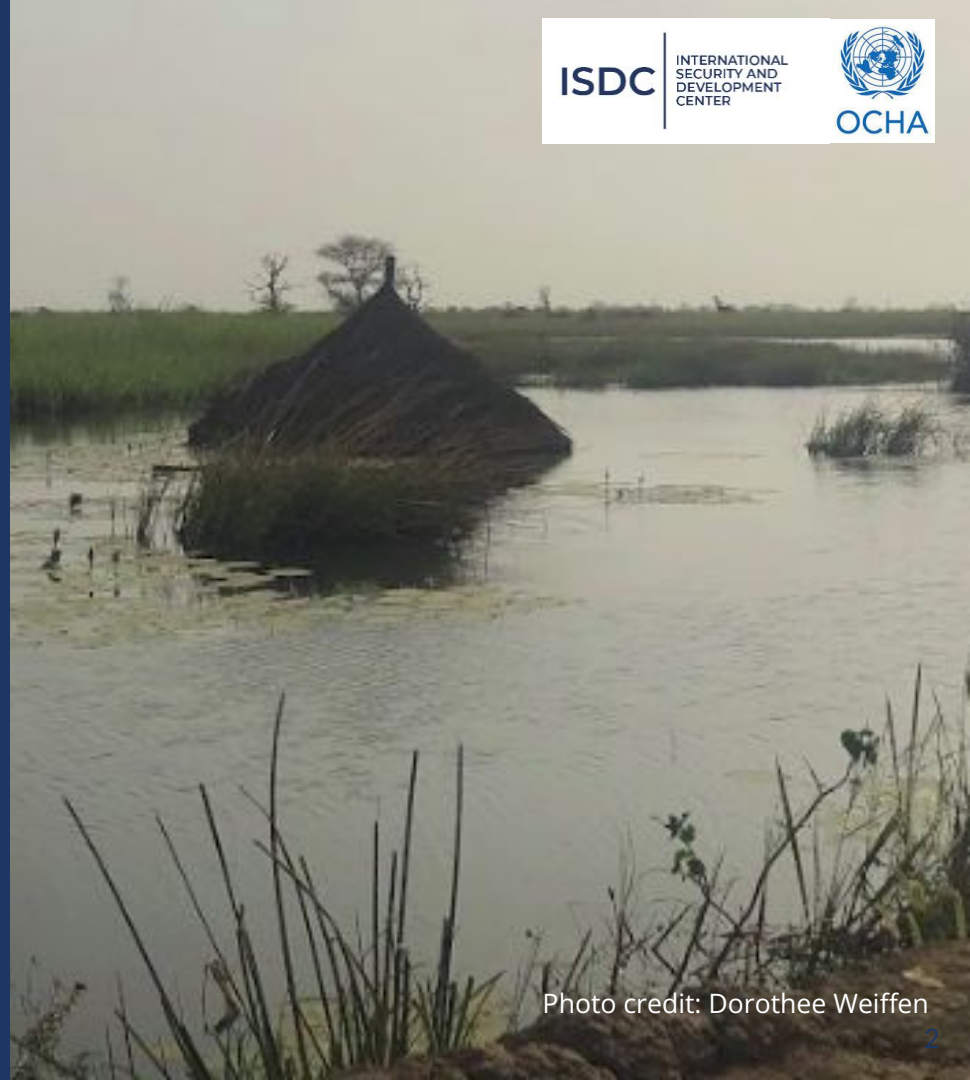


Photo credit: Dorothee Weiffen

Targeted/Rapid review of AA impacts

- Interventions delivered before a climatic shock based on early warning information or forecast-based triggers
- Google Scholar (10 pages), Anticipation Hub and Relief Web platforms
- 2010 - 2025, English only
- Clear identification of a comparison group (experimental or quasi experimental)
- LMICs only
- **14 included studies**

**187 records
identified**

176 excluded

(not relevant, not AA, not
experimental or quasi
experimental, duplicates)

**11 included
from search
(+ 3 from own
knowledge)**

Details of included studies



Country

Bangladesh (4)
Mongolia (2)
Mozambique (1)
Nepal (1)
Niger (1)
Nigeria (1)
Peru (2)
Somaliland (1)
South Sudan (1)



Hazard

Floods (8)
Cold wave (3)
Cyclone (2)
Drought (1)



Intervention

Cash (10)
In-kind (4)



Design

RCT (5)
Quasi-experimental: PSM (6)
Quasi-experimental: Other (3)



Type

Journal articles (6)
Working papers (4)
Reports (4)

	Economic	Food security & nutrition	Health & wellbeing	Pre-emptive actions	Social cohesion	
Early vs. post-shock support						Cyclone
Early vs. no support						
Early vs. post-shock support						Cold wave
Early vs. no support	\$					
Early vs. post-shock support	\$ \$ \$	\$ \$ \$	\$ \$ \$		\$	Drought
Early vs. no support						
Early vs. post-shock support	\$ \$ \$ \$	\$ \$ \$K \$ \$	\$ \$ \$ \$	\$ \$ \$K \$K		Floods
Early vs. no support						

Intervention codes: \$ = Cash K = In-kind

Impact direction:

positive

null

negative

	Economic	Food security & nutrition	Health & wellbeing	Pre-emptive actions	Social cohesion	
Early vs. post-shock support						Cyclone
Early vs. no support	K		K	K		
Early vs. post-shock support						Cold wave
Early vs. no support	\$ K \$ \$		K	K		
Early vs. post-shock support	\$ \$ \$	\$ \$ \$	\$ \$ \$		\$	Drought
Early vs. no support						
Early vs. post-shock support	\$ \$ \$ \$	\$ \$K \$ \$ \$K \$	\$ \$ \$	\$ \$K \$ \$K		Floods
Early vs. no support	\$ \$ \$ \$ \$ \$ \$ K	\$ \$ \$ \$ \$	\$ \$ \$ \$ \$ \$ \$ K	\$ \$ \$ \$ \$ \$ \$	\$ \$	

Intervention codes: \$ = Cash K = In-kind

Impact direction:

positive

null

negative

Preliminary lessons and research priorities

- Generate **evidence on additional sectors** including WASH, education, and protection
- **Harmonize measurement** with standardized, comparable indicators to enable cross-context analysis
- Assess **modalities beyond cash**, across crisis types, and test transfer size, frequency, duration, and targeting
- Collect sex-disaggregated data and examine gender dynamics and **intra-household distribution** of costs and benefits
- Assess **long-term impacts** under repeated shocks and compare costs and benefits of early vs. late response across outcomes

Cash and Cohesion in Crisis:

The Impacts of Anticipatory Cash Transfers in Flooded IDP Camps in South Sudan

Dorothee Weiffen

Ghassan Baliki

Jan Elfes

Tilman Brück

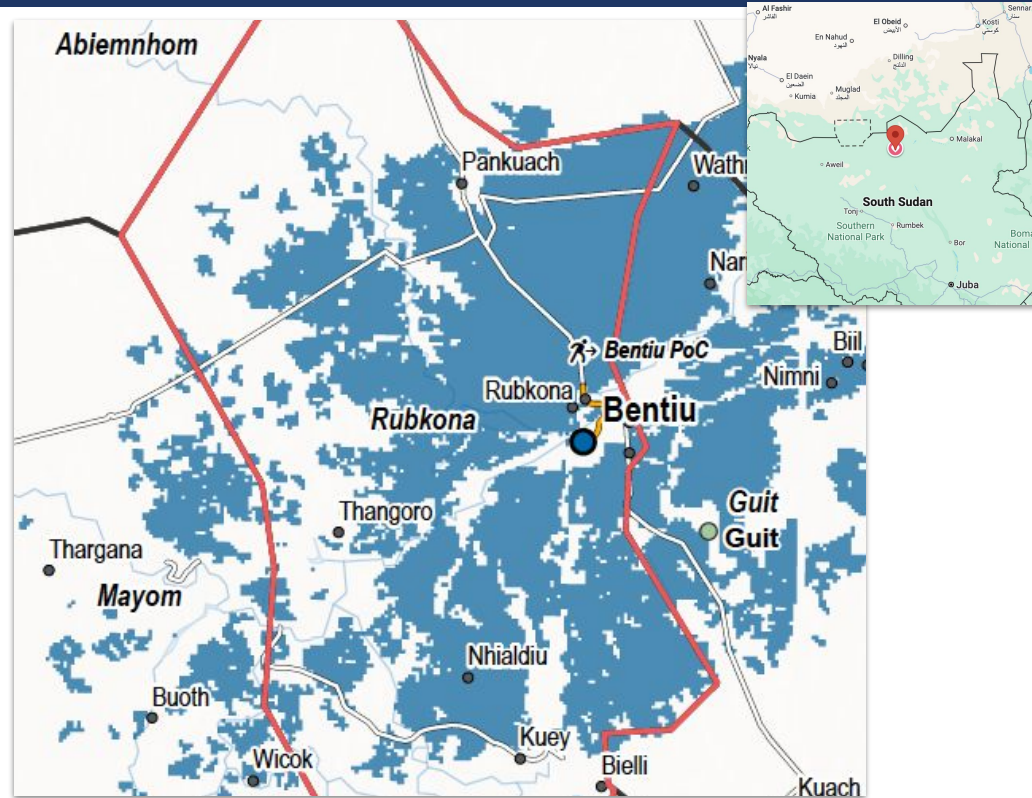


Photo credit: Hon Stephen Gatphan

Context

Bentiu, South Sudan

- 440,000 **IDPs** in Unity State (UNOCHA, 2022)
- Only 10% of Bentiu city residents are **host** population
- Trauma from **civil war** (2013-2018)
- Weak protection from severe recurrent and lasting **floods**
- Strong dependency on **UN assistance** in formal and informal camps



Notes. Estimated flood extent, Rubkona county - August 2022
(UNOSAT, REACH, 2022)

The intervention

- **Target population**

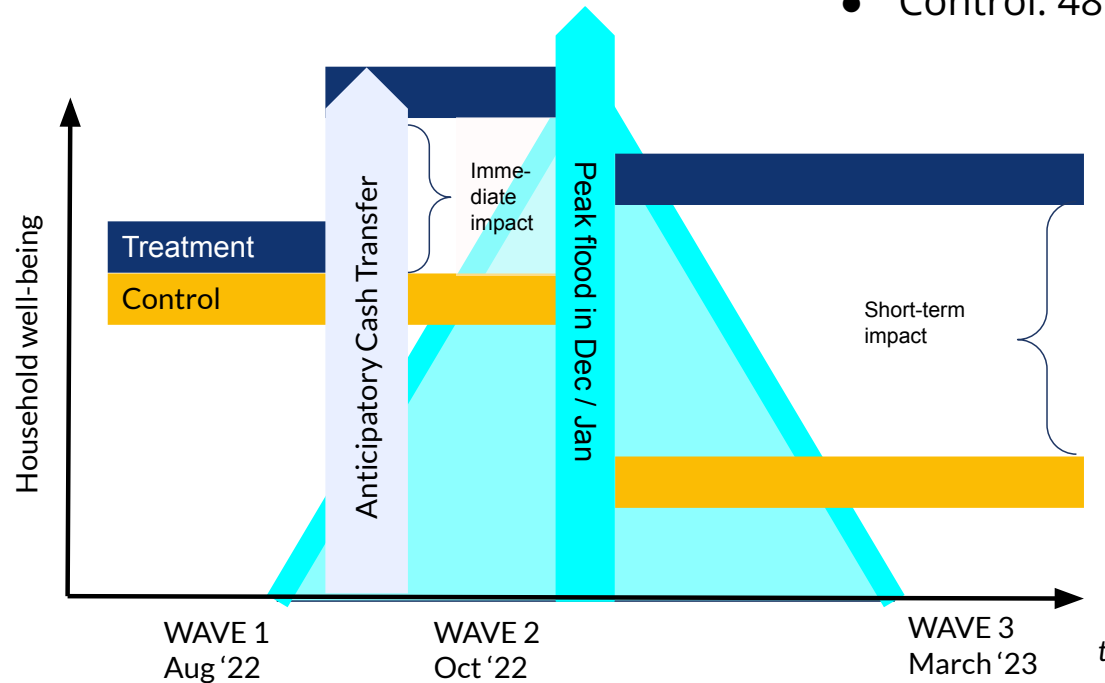
- female-headed households
- households with elderly persons
- households with persons with disabilities
- = 15% of households in study sites

- **Unconditional cash transfer**

- provided at onset of floods
- one-off payment of 65 USD
- representing approx. 50% of monthly HH expenditure



Study design



Sample & identification:

- Treatment: 453 female-headed HH
- Control: 489 'next-eligible' female-headed HH



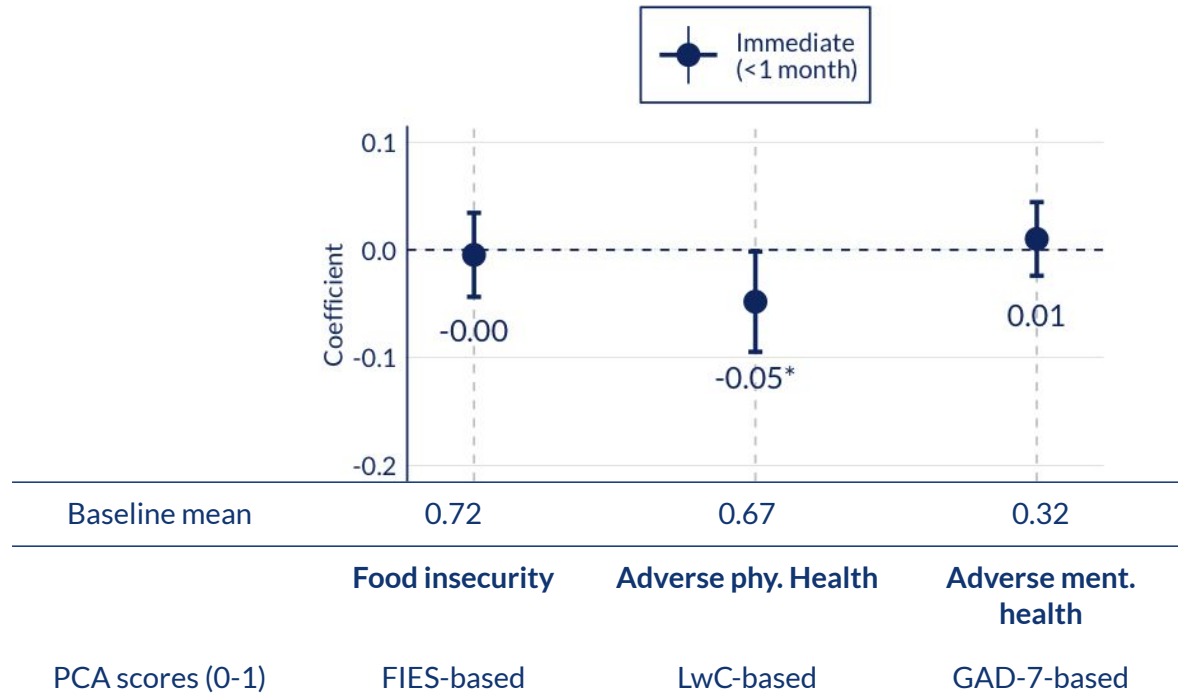
Photo credit: William Kuen

Baseline levels and balance

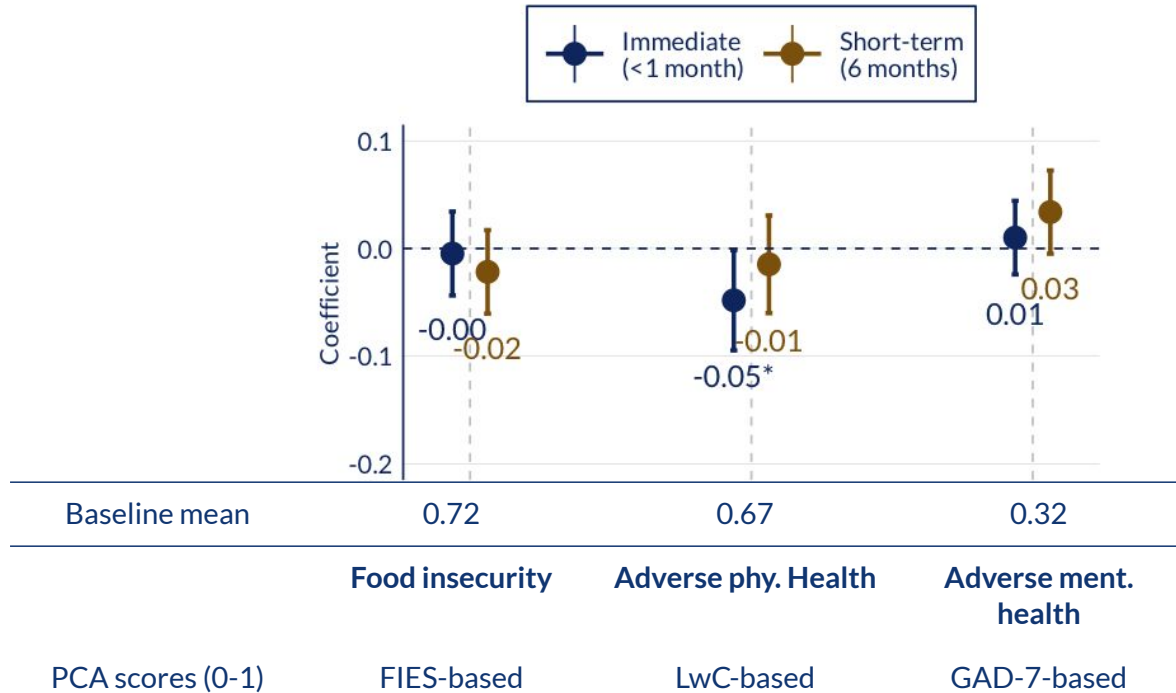
		Control	Treatment	P-value
Selection criteria	Age HHH (years)	39.0 (12.6)	40.7 (13.5)	.042
	Ratio of female adults	.61 (.24)	.6 (.23)	.254
	Ratio of disabled HH members	.15 (.18)	.15 (.18)	.579
HH characteristics	Literacy HHH (proportion)	.17 (.37)	.17 (.38)	.992
	# HH members	9.8 (4.5)	9.5 (4.6)	.331
	# children in HH	6.4 (2.8)	6.2 (3.0)	.457
Shelter conditions (proportions)	Bad shelter condition	.59 (.49)	.63 (.49)	.212
	Water leaks	.94 (.24)	.97 (.17)	.027
Impacted by adverse shocks (proportions)	Floods (6 months)	.99 (.06)	.99 (.11)	.215
	Displacement inside camp (3 weeks)	.59 (.49)	.63 (.49)	.212
	Conflict (6 months)	.46 (.4)	.47 (.5)	.813
	Theft (6 months)	.45 (.5)	.48 (.5)	.376
N		489	453	

Notes: Baseline means with standard deviations in parentheses and p-value from two-sided t-tests.

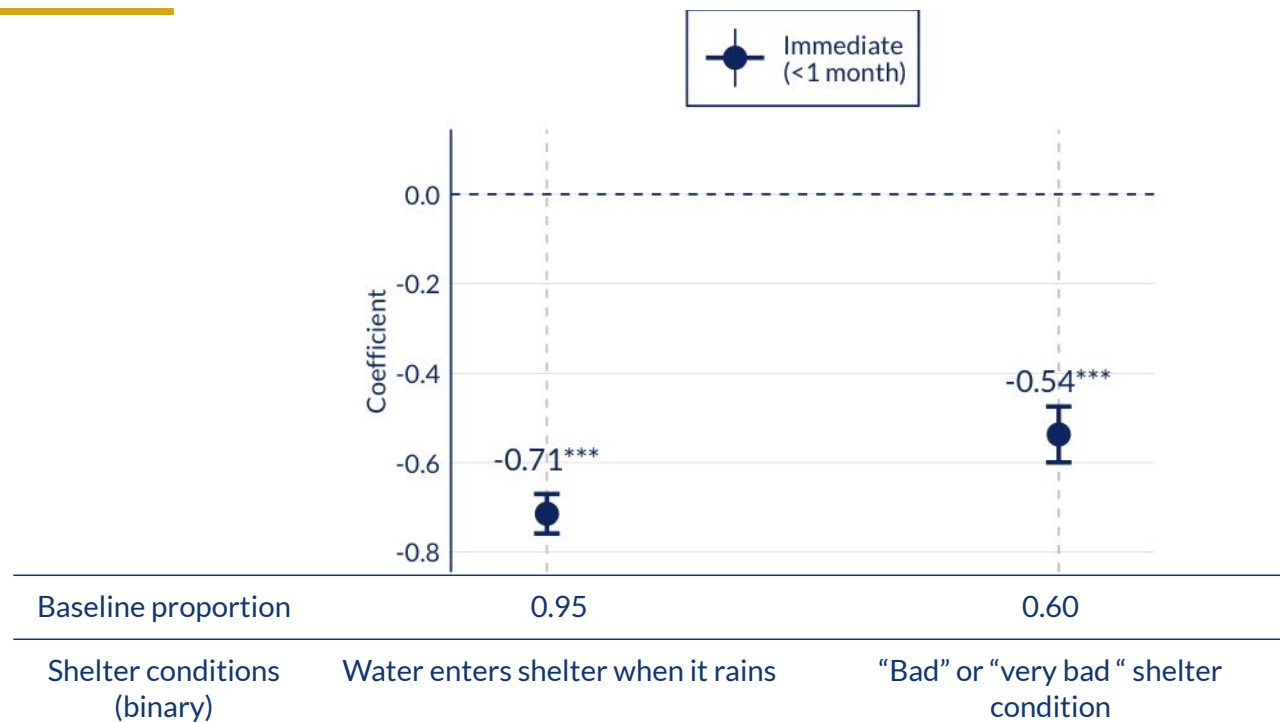
Marginal immediate improvements in wellbeing



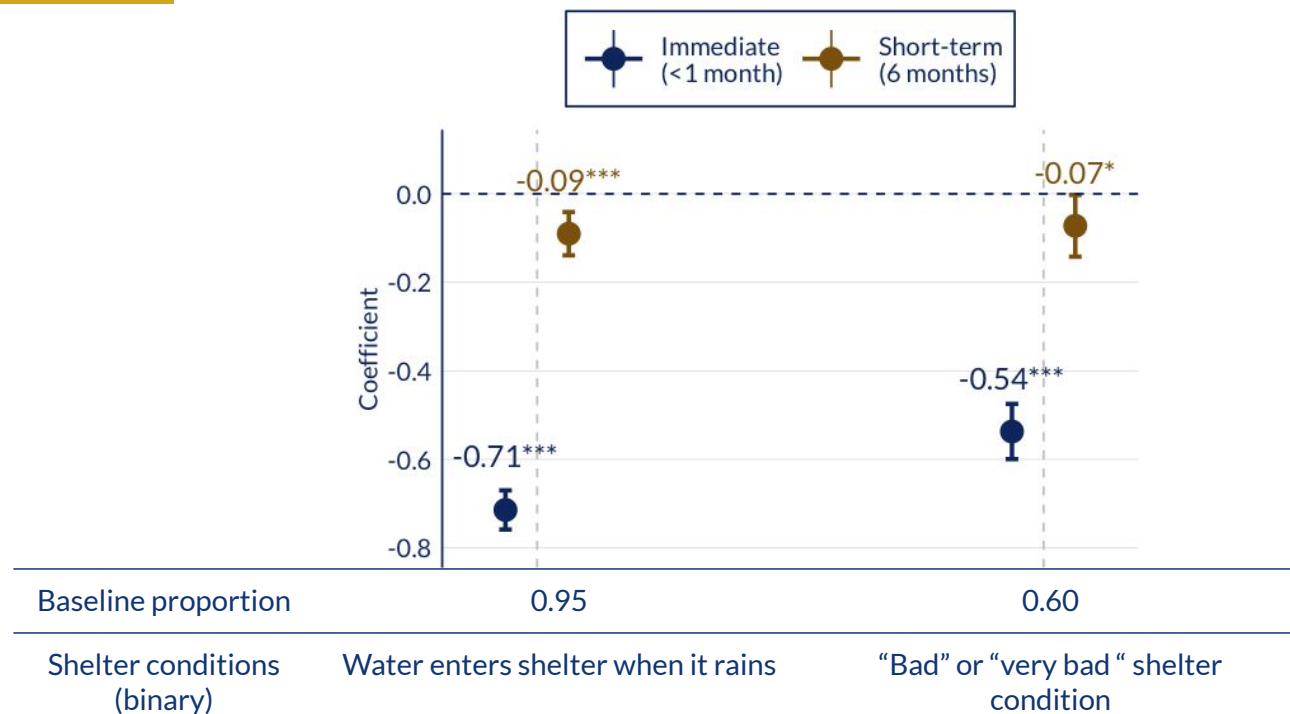
Which dissipate with the floods



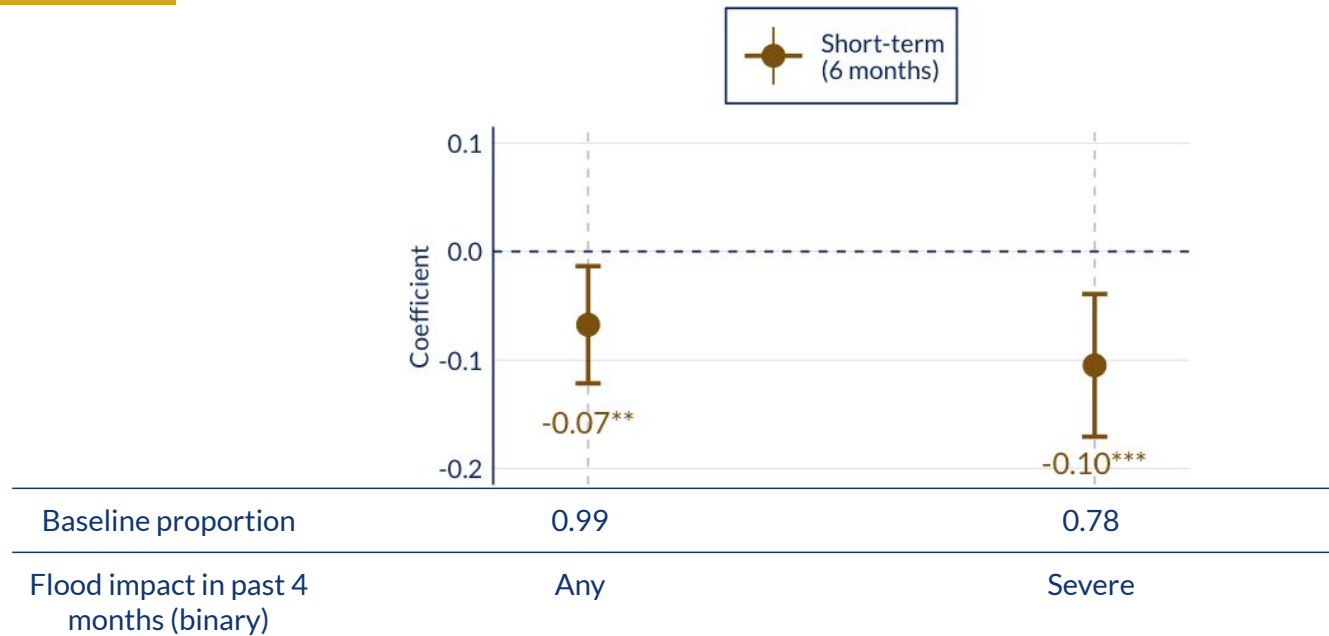
Cash transfers improve shelter conditions



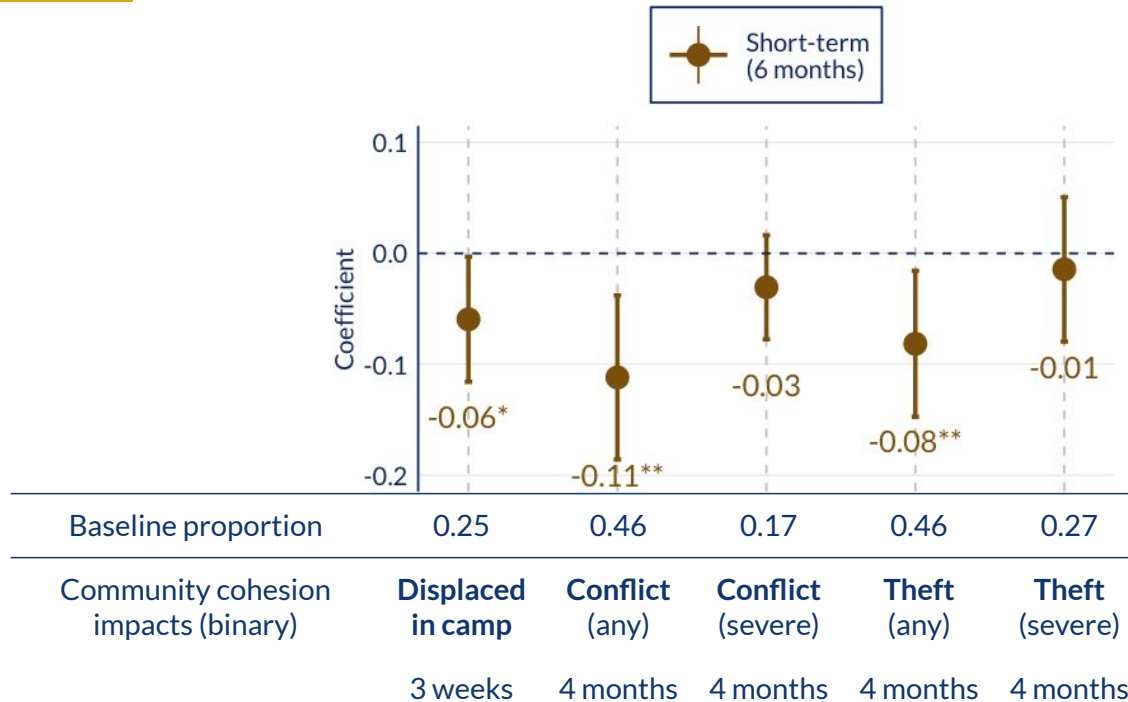
Cash transfers improve shelter conditions, however...



Reduction in flood impacts



Strong impacts on community cohesion



Mechanism: Safe shelters



THANK YOU!

Ghassan Baliki
Director, Welfare Research Program
ISDC Berlin

baliki@isdc.org



Photo credit: Hon Stephen Gatphan